Aliah Pacalna Cali-Pascan

Aliah Pacalna Cali-Pascan, JD, DPA, Sh.C. is a Filipino academic executive, legal practitioner, and peace strategist based in Marawi City, Philippines.

She holds the position of **Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs** at Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus, where she holds the rank of Chancellor 1.

Her career sits at the intersection of public administration, Islamic jurisprudence, and community-based peacebuilding, making her one of the more distinctive academic leaders in the Bangsamoro region.

Dr. Cali-Pascan is widely recognized for her leadership during two of Marawi's most difficult chapters: the 2017 Marawi Siege and the COVID-19 pandemic lockdowns of 2020.

Beyond crisis management, she has built a sustained body of work around institutional reform, women's advocacy, transitional justice, and the push to officially designate MSU as a "National Peace University."

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Aliah Pacalna Cali-Pascan



Full Name	Aliah Pacalna Cali-Pascan
Credentials	JD, DPA, Sh.C.
Current Position	Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs, MSU Main Campus
Rank	Chancellor 1
Institution	Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus
Based In	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Designations	Peace Action Officer, MSU Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao (IPDM)
Spouse	Walid Bacaraman Pascan
Children	Faris Sufyan Cali Pascan
Nationality	Filipino

Background and Credentials

Dr. Cali-Pascan brings together a rare mix of qualifications that span three distinct but complementary fields.

Her **Juris Doctor (JD)** grounds her firmly in Philippine statutory and constitutional law, giving her the legal vocabulary to engage policy, institutional governance, and conflict resolution with precision.

The **Doctor of Public Administration (DPA)** feeds directly into her reform-oriented work inside MSU's administrative structure, where systems thinking and institutional efficiency aren't just concepts but daily practice.

What sets her apart further is the **Shari'ah Counselor (Sh.C.)** designation, which qualifies her to practice and consult within the Philippines' Shari'ah court system.

This credential puts her at the crossroads of alternative dispute resolution (ADR), Islamic arbitration, and community mediation, areas that are especially consequential in Muslim Mindanao where formal and customary legal systems often overlap.

Together, these credentials reflect a career built not just on academic achievement but on the practical need to serve a community where law, faith, and governance are deeply intertwined.

Career at Mindanao State University

Early Administrative Work

Before her elevation to a senior executive role, Dr. Cali-Pascan served as **Executive Assistant III** under the MSU Office of the President.

It was in this capacity that she drove some of the university's most important modernization initiatives.

She oversaw MSU's compliance with the **Anti-Red Tape Act (ARTA)**, the national legislation designed to cut bureaucratic delays in public services, ensuring that students, faculty, and the general public could access university services without unnecessary friction.

She also led the implementation of MSU's **Strategic Performance Management System (SPMS)** and championed the adoption of a university-wide **Quality Management System (QMS)**, bringing MSU's administrative processes into alignment with recognized quality standards.

These weren't flashy reforms, but they were consequential: the kind of structural groundwork that makes an institution more resilient, more accountable, and more responsive to the people it serves.

Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs

In December 2022, Dr. Cali-Pascan was designated to the permanent position of **Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs** at MSU Main Campus, carrying the rank of Chancellor 1.

In this role, she oversees academic policy development, faculty development programs, and the alignment of the university's various academic systems.

The position places her at the center of MSU's long-term institutional direction, particularly as the university continues to define its role in post-conflict Marawi.

Crisis Leadership

The 2017 Marawi Siege

When the Marawi Siege erupted in May 2017, Dr. Cali-Pascan was serving as **Director of the MSU-Marawi Presidential Management Staff (PMS)**.

The siege placed MSU in an extraordinarily difficult position: a civilian academic institution suddenly surrounded by active armed conflict, with students and personnel caught in the middle.

Her role as liaison between the university and external security forces required careful, high-stakes negotiation on a near-daily basis.

She defended the temporary military presence on campus as a necessary measure for student safety, while simultaneously working to ensure that soldiers remained out of academic buildings so that students wouldn't feel intimidated or surveilled in their own learning spaces.

She also arranged for female soldiers to assist during post-siege enrollment periods, a practical and sensitive measure aimed at making female students feel safer returning to campus.

It was a difficult position to navigate publicly, but her decisions during that period reflected a consistent priority: protect the students, keep the academic mission alive, and maintain the university's integrity as a civilian space.

COVID-19 and the 2020 Lockdown

The pandemic brought a different kind of crisis to MSU.

When Marawi entered Enhanced Community Quarantine (ECQ) in 2020, more than **1,500 students** were suddenly stranded on campus with no clear path home.

Dr. Cali-Pascan coordinated the massive logistical effort to manage, feed, and safely repatriate all of them, a task that required careful coordination across multiple agencies and barangays under strict lockdown conditions.

Her handling of this situation demonstrated the same quality that defined her work during the Marawi Siege: a calm, practical focus on the welfare of students even under institutional pressure.

Peace Advocacy

The National Peace University Campaign

As a designated **Peace Action Officer** for MSU's **Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao (IPDM)**, Dr. Cali-Pascan has become one of the leading voices behind the campaign to officially recognize and legally certify MSU as a **National Peace University**.

This isn't a symbolic gesture. The campaign is a strategic initiative backed by the university's Board of Regents, aiming to institutionalize MSU's peace-oriented mission and give it national standing.

She is one of the primary authors of this initiative, which frames MSU's entire existence, especially its persistence through conflict and recovery, as proof of the university's unique qualification for the designation.

Radio Advocacy: #ShuaraMSU

To reach beyond the campus and into the community, Dr. Cali-Pascan hosts **#ShuaraMSU** (which translates to "The Voice of MSU"), a radio program broadcast over **Radyo Pilipinas Marawi (97.5 FM)**.

The program covers stories of local peacebuilders, Bangsamoro heritage and culture, and discussions on the region's historical narrative.

She has used the platform to feature cultural programming as well, including film screenings of Dekada '70, reflecting her belief that cultural memory is part of the peace process.

Grassroots Mediation Training

Through partnerships with international organizations like **World Vision**, Dr. Cali-Pascan conducts hands-on mediation training for members of the **Lupon Tagapamayapa** (local village justice councils) in Marawi barangays.

The goal is practical: give grassroots community leaders formal mediation frameworks they can actually use to resolve disputes before they escalate.

In a city where clan-based conflict (rido) has historically led to cycles of violence, this kind of community-level capacity building is seen as one of the most effective long-term interventions available.

Women's Leadership and Transitional Justice

Bae a Tomanor (B'TARA)

Dr. Cali-Pascan is an active and prominent member of **Bae a Tomanor (B'TARA)**, an organization that brings together women royalty, officials, and academic leaders in Lanao del Sur.

Through B'TARA, she advocates for women to serve as "Third Siders" in community conflicts, that is, as trusted, neutral parties who can enter volatile situations and help de-escalate tensions without being seen as aligned with any one clan or faction.

In the context of Maranao society, where rido (clan feuds) can persist for generations, having women from respected families and institutions take on this mediating role carries real cultural weight.

Transitional Justice and Cultural Repatriation

Dr. Cali-Pascan is also a vocal advocate for cultural repatriation, arguing that the return of historical artifacts to Muslim Mindanao is not simply a cultural issue but a matter of collective dignity and historical justice for the Bangsamoro people.

She frames transitional justice in this broader sense: healing a community means addressing not only the physical destruction of war but also the erasure of cultural memory and the displacement of heritage.

International Dialogue

She represents MSU in international academic and diplomatic spaces, including dialogues with global delegations such as Indonesia's **Leimena Group**.

These engagements are aimed at building cross-border networks across Southeast Asia around themes of religious freedom, interfaith dialogue, and moderate Islamic education, areas where MSU can position itself as a regional thought leader.

Legacy and Significance

Dr. Cali-Pascan's career is a study in what it looks like to hold institutional and community roles simultaneously without losing sight of either.

She's a university administrator who also sits in village mediation sessions. She's a Shari'ah counselor who designs university quality management systems. She's a peace strategist who runs a radio program.

What connects all of it is a consistent orientation toward the people of Marawi and the Bangsamoro region: keeping them educated, keeping them safe, and working to make sure their culture, history, and dignity are part of any post-conflict future.

Her push to name MSU a National Peace University is perhaps the clearest expression of that vision: not just rebuilding an institution, but insisting that what MSU has lived through gives it a specific and permanent role in the national peace narrative.

Recognition

Dr. Cali-Pascan's work has been recognized within MSU's institutional framework through her designation as Peace Action Officer under IPDM and her permanent appointment as Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs.

Her advocacy through the National Peace University campaign and her crisis leadership during the Marawi Siege and the COVID-19 pandemic have positioned her as one of the more visible academic peace advocates in Muslim Mindanao.

Personal Life

Dr. Cali-Pascan is married to **Walid Bacaraman Pascan** and is a mother to their son, **Faris Sufyan Cali Pascan**.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao
- Battle of Marawi
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Lupon Tagapamayapa
- Shari'ah Courts in the Philippines
- Bae a Tomanor

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